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PUBLIC PERCEPTIONS OF A DIVIDED MYANMAR

Findings from the 2015 Myanmar Asian Barometer Survey

Bridget Welsh and Kai-Ping Huang

A dominant image of Myanmar's politics is one of conflict. Whether it is the bloodshed over fighting in the Kokang region and the exodus of Rohingyas from Rakhine State, the struggle between young students against the police in protest, or the contestation among leaders and between democratic forces led by the National League for Democracy (NLD) and the Tatmadaw, the lens that frames Burmese politics is one of division. This was especially the case in the pivotal year of 2015, the year of the contentious November election that witnessed the decisive victory of the NLD.

Rather than examine underlying dynamics of specific issues or explore the causes of a particular conflict in depth, this chapter looks at conflict from the views of ordinary citizens. It uses the data from the Asian Barometer